

otherwise, they will turn green and spoil. When the stems reach about 9 in (23 cm) tall, pile soil up around them, leaving about 4 in (10 cm) of foliage above the surface. You may need to repeat this process a couple of times, depending on how tall the plants grow. Cut back the stems of larger varieties in late summer or early fall to 2 in (5 cm) above the soil.

HARVESTING

New potatoes should be ready to harvest in 60–90 days, midseason in 90–110 days, and late varieties in 120 days, or more. Check that tubers are ready to harvest by scraping back some of the soil and examining them. It is best to lift potatoes on a dry day, and then leave them out in the sun for a few hours before storing. Ensure that no tubers are left in the soil or they are likely to regrow the following year.

STORING

Potatoes will store well in double-layered paper or burlap bags in a cool, dry, well-ventilated place. Ensure that they are properly dried out—the drier they are when you store them, the better they'll keep. Also check that potatoes are completely covered, with no light reaching them.

PESTS AND DISEASES

Pests that may damage your potatoes include cutworms, wireworms, slugs, and Colorado potato beetles. The best ways to prevent these are to control weeds, defend crops against slugs and snails, and try not to leave tubers in the ground longer than necessary.

The most serious disease is potato blight, an airborne fungus that infects plants in continuously wet weather, and usually affects later maturing varieties at the end of the summer. The stems and leaves wither and tubers rot. Other diseases include potato common scab, potato blackleg, and powdery scab.

Include potatoes in a three-year crop rotation to avoid common pests and diseases persisting in the soil. Plant potatoes where you have grown beans or peas in the previous year.



Colorado beetles (left) are a serious pest and can be controlled organically with Bt applications. **Potato blight (right)** causes plants to shrivel and die.